# Chris Cowherd

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***Software Engineering Leader***

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***30 Years of Software Engineering Leadership***

Extensive experience in a technical leadership role
Engineering manager and hands-on contributor
Thought leader, inventor and implementer of protocol standards and systems
Strategic, analytical and highly personable, with a collaborative, inclusive leadership style
Adept at seeing the big picture, building strong teams and driving positive outcomes

**Transparent • Trustworthy • Inclusive • Accessible • Passionate**

## Core Competencies

- Software Development
- Risk Management
- Privacy Compliance
- IT Platform Development
- Cloud Native Expertise
- Team Building / Leadership
- Information Security
- AI & Data Analytics
- Technology Diligence & Audits
- Financial Integration
- Acquisition & Transition
- Strategic Planning
- Tooling & Automation
- Vendor Management

## Professional Summary

### Backend Software Engineer, Generative AI
BlestX Ventures, LLC - Redmond, WA — 2023 - Present
*Private research integrating generative AI for manufacturing processes*

### Chief Technology Officer
i2 Holdings dba Ambassador Software - Seattle, WA — 2020 - 2022
*Private equity funded SaaS company executing roll-up strategy in marketing technology AI & Analytics*

### Principal Software Engineer
Stahurricane LLC - Bellevue, WA — 2018 – 2021
*Venture vehicle for ex-CEO of Donuts & eNom.*

### Chief Technology Officer
Donuts Inc. - Bellevue, WA — 2012 - 2018
*World's largest top-level domain registry operator*

### Senior Engineering Manager, R&D
Demand Media (RightSide / Leaf Group) - Kirkland, WA — 2008 – 2012
*Content & media generation, monetization*

### Software Engineering Manager
eNom, Inc - Redmond, WA — 2000 – 2008
*Wholesale white-label platform for domains, email, and SSL*

## PROFESSIONAL DETAILS

### BACKEND SOFTWARE ENGINEER, GENERATIVE AI

BlestX Ventures, LLC - Redmond, WA 2023 - Present

*Private research integrating generative AI for manufacturing processes*
*Stack: OpenAI, Python, Go, Flask, Google Cloud, Docker*

- Integrate OpenAI technology
- Hand-crafted PDF parsing and ingestion
- Retrieval augmented generation (RAG) w/ Weaviate & Pinecone
- Prompt engineering
- Reranking results with cross-encoders
- Expand search surface area with synthesized data
- Customized workflow with extensive LLM function calling
- Distributed LLM agent coordination
- Fine tuning to optimize output of code generation

### CHIEF TECHNOLOGY OFFICER

i2 Holdings dba Ambassador Software - Seattle, WA 2020 - 2022

*Private equity funded SaaS company executing roll-up strategy in marketing technology AI & Analytics*
*Stack: Python, Go, PostgreSQL, Django, Google Cloud, AWS, Docker, GDPR, CCPA & SOC2 Compliance*

- Ultimate responsibility to protect, secure and advance all company technology assets
- Leader and champion for 18 geographically distributed engineers; onshore, nearshore and offshore
- Customer driven product owner, product roadmap development, strategic planning
- Full lifecycle owner and leader for design, development, testing, deployment and maintenance
- Coach and mentor for team career development and personal growth
- Reliable project execution and delivery time after time through careful planning, tracking and expectation management

### PRINCIPAL SOFTWARE ENGINEER

Stahurricane LLC - Bellevue, WA 2018 – 2021

*Venture vehicle for ex-CEO of Donuts & eNom.*
*Stack: Go, Python, C#, CUDA, HLSL Compute Shaders, Unity, Google Cloud, AWS, Docker*

- R&D software design & development of VR and mathematical research
- Designed and developed distributed system to explore and visualize difficult to solve mathematical areas using cloud GPUs (see: https://zeta-machine.chriscowherd.com/)
- Designed and developed distributed cloud-native system to perform ML inference at scale (see: https://github.com/chriscow/cloud-scanner-go)
- Designed and developed distributed brute force system to discover fundamental constants (see: https://github.com/chriscow/ramanujan-machine)
- Designed and developed application in Unity to use GPUs to visualize and explore higher dimension structures (12 dimension) and project those down to 4-dimensions then a 2-dimensional plane

## CHIEF TECHNOLOGY OFFICER

Donuts Inc. - Bellevue, WA 2012 - 2018

*World's largest top-level domain registry operator*

*Stack: Python, Go, C#, PostgreSQL, Django, Google Cloud, AWS, Docker, GDPR Compliance*

- *Provide critical functionality for proper functioning of the Internet naming infrastructure*
- *Manage full lifecycle for Internet-critical software systems, quality assurance, network & ops*
- *Scale growth while maintaining ICANN mandated uptime for global Internet infrastructure*
- *Successfully launched and operated over 200 TLDs without incident*
- *Grew **600x** from '13 – '16; named #1 on Deloitte Fast 500 as fastest growing company in No. America*

***Key responsibilities:***

- Corporate Technology / Product Development / Incident Management / Risk Management
- Operations, security, budgeting, technology audits, business continuity and M&A diligence
- Team building and leadership in and across organizations

***Management Portfolio:*** *(15 direct reports, organization of 45)*

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Platform Development | Tooling and automation | Operations & technical support |
| Quality assurance | Data warehousing, analytics & AI | Financial backend integration |
| Corporate IT & facilities | Business intelligence | Corporate & Physical Security |
| Production engineering | | |

## SENIOR ENGINEERING MANAGER, R&D

Demand Media (RightSide / Leaf Group) - Kirkland, WA 2008 – 2012

*Content & media generation, monetization*

*Stack: C#, SQL Server, Redis*

- Leader, manager and mentor for 12 cross-discipline engineers
- Develop many successful POCs by fostering creativity and input from all team members
- Full SDLC using agile methodologies and continuous integration
- Design and initial implementation of the world's largest domain name registry

## SOFTWARE ENGINEERING MANAGER

eNom, Inc - Redmond, WA 2000 – 2008

*Wholesale white-label platform for domains, email, and SSL*

*Stack: C++, C#, SQL Server*

**Software Engineering Mgr** 2004 - 2008
**Principal Software Engineer** 2000 – 2004

- Managed and coached team of 7 engineers while individual contributor
- Devised scalable server architectures for long running services such as DNS
- Networking and Internet protocol development for DNS, SMTP, POP, IMAP etc.
- Designed scalable, fault tolerant systems
- Guided and mentored team through uncertainty

**Microsoft**, Redmond, WA 1997 - 2000

**Software Design Engineer**

World class development experience, including key contributions to early stages of **Internet Explorer**, Windows and Office

**Advanced Semiconductor**, Phoenix, AZ 1994 - 1996

**Programmer / Analyst**

Designed and developed tools for managing engineering changes to semiconductor processing equipment

## Patents

U.S. Patent # US11552923B2
Whitelist domain name registry

U.S. Patent # US20160173440A1
Communication using dns repurposing

U.S. Patent # US20150100507A1
*Domain Protected Marks List Service*

U.S. Patent # US20080273077
*Virtual Video Message Answering Machine Platform*

U.S. Patent # US20080281676
*Methods and Systems to Facilitate Keyword Bid Arbitrage with Multiple Advertisement Placement Providers*

## Education

Glendale College - Mathematics / Computer Science 1996